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Unit 6

Poem

The Hollow Crown
(from Richard II)

William Shakespeare

Warm up

a. Work with a partner and take this short quiz to find out how well informed you are about history.

- Name a few wars and battles you have read about.
- What is the difference between a war and a battle?
- Why do rulers wage wars and battles?
- Is the outcome of a war always fair?
- Do you think rulers understand the true meaning of life – in defeat or in victory?
- Can you name a few kings and leaders who have fallen from glory to disgrace?



b. The historical background:

The poem is an extract from William Shakespeare's play **King Richard the Second**. The play is based on true events that occurred towards the end of the 14th century.

Richard II was crowned the King of England in the year 1367. He continued to be the British Monarch until 1399, when he was deposed by his cousin, Henry of Bolingbroke, who crowned himself King Henry the Fourth in the same year. Shakespeare's play is a dramatic rendition of the last two years of King Richard II's life. In this brief span of time, he was ousted from his royal position and sent to prison, where he died in captivity.

The following extract is set in the Coast of Wales. King Richard and some of his followers awaited the arrival of the Welsh army [*after facing defeat at the hands of his cousin, Bolingbroke*], of about 10000 warriors. But to their shock and surprise, they received the message that the army was not coming to their rescue. His followers tried to boost their King's courage against the news, only in vain. When Richard came face to face with the reality of his terrible fate, he spoke the following verse, famously known as the "Hollow Crown" speech in theatrical circles. In it, King Richard is reminded of the power of Death that overshadows everything else, including the power of rulers, and renders them as powerless as any commoner at a moment's notice.